

LOCATION

The Highlands occupy the northern and western half of Scotland.

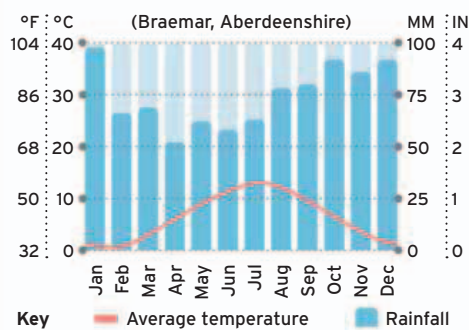
ATLANTIC
OCEAN

North
Sea



CLIMATE

Cool temperate, heavily influenced by Atlantic weather systems bringing frequent precipitation and high winds, and by altitude.



Western red deer

Cervus elaphus

long, slender legs



The largest animal in Scotland (and in many other European countries), the red deer is named after the color of its fur during the summer. At this time, the deer have a short coat, and small herds can be seen browsing in open habitats. In winter, the coat grows thick and gray as the deer retreat into woodlands that offer more shelter in bad weather.

Red deer live in single sex herds, but mixing is tolerated in winter. As spring arrives the males start to grow antlers,

and the females give birth to spotted fawns. The rut begins in late summer. Dominant males control a harem of females, using a bellowing roar to keep them together. The weaker bucks, the young and the old, harass the females at the edge of the group, driving them toward the protection of the stronger males. The rut lasts until the arrival of winter, when the males shed their antlers, and the deer prepare for cold conditions once more.

- ↔ 6–7 ft (1.8–2.1m)
- ⚖ 165–485 lb (75–220 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Leaves, grasses, sedges
- 🏠



Europe to W. Asia, N. Africa

mature buck has several points on each antler

antler bone grows 1 in (2.5 cm) per day

▷ STANDING PROUD

Females judge males by their antlers. Younger bucks have fewer points, or tines, while the antlers of aging males are less symmetrical.



△ HEADS DOWN

Rutting bucks try to avoid all-out combat. They walk side by side to size each other up and will only fight if neither backs down.

ASSISTED RECOVERY
Water voles saw a huge decline in the UK in the late 20th century, partly due to heavy predation by introduced American mink. But because Highland river catchments are too exposed for mink, the voles have a refuge here.

highest mountain in Britain

WATER VOLE

